

Fighting Traffic: The Dawn of the Motor Age in the American City
Peter Norton, 2011, MIT Press

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In the acknowledgements of *Fighting Traffic: The Dawn of the Motor Age in the American City*, Peter Norton describes a form of time-travel: leaving his job in the basement of the Historical Society of Delaware, where he had been sorting through photos of Wilmington in the 1910s, and emerging into the corresponding 1988 streetscape. At some point between 1910 and 1988, these streets became the rightful home of the personal motor vehicle. In his book, Dr. Norton pinpoints this shift and traces the contentious debate over the legitimacy of automobiles on city streets from the mid-1910s to the 1930s. As a historian, Norton de-naturalizes the presence of cars in the street by taking readers back to the years just before cars “won” the streets and tracing the transition. Norton argues that the primacy of the personal vehicle in the city street was accomplished by a concerted effort by several actors - most chiefly, motor vehicle interests - to redefine the problems of safety and congestion. Popular discontent or fear around these issues, which were raised by a diversity of groups, were seen as a threat to motor vehicle sales that required active rebuttal. In documenting the transition, Norton reveals this question to be a question of resource governance: who decides how road space is allocated to uses and users, and from where did that actor get that authority?

Norton frames his historical evidence around *problem definitions* or *technological frames* (following Pinch and Bijker, 1984): a shared set of perspectives that define how a problem is seen, and what solutions are implied by this definition. He examines two new public concerns that arose out of the appearance of cars on the city street: safety and congestion. These problems were chronologically overlapping, but Norton treats them separately to highlight the varying problem definitions proposed by different stakeholder or identity groups for each.

When Norton cites concerns about safety in this period, he highlights a staggering number of automobile deaths: over 15,000 dead in 1923 (this puts the per-capita death rate from automobiles higher than in 2021, despite per capita rate of automobile ownership being much lower). The majority of the public, he claims, saw cars as “murderers,” “juggernauts,” or “death-dealing monsters” (pp 27-29). In the early 1920s, parents, pedestrians, and local safety councils characterized the issue of safety as an issue with the car, and its speed, itself. Police saw the safety issue as one of disorder - a lack of regulation and control. Local chambers of commerce more or less aligned with police in demanding order, hoping that the purchase of infrastructure could ensure it: physical items like guide posts for left turns and synchronized turn signals. While the latter two groups may have made concessions for the presence of cars in the street, they agreed with the problem definition that the safety issue was one inherent to the car itself, a consequence of its uniquely high speed.

Beginning slightly later but overlapping significantly with safety concerns were business leaders’ concerns with the physical space taken up by cars, and the ensuing congestion of the streets. Traffic engineers, members of a new profession, saw themselves as regulators of a public utility (much like the relatively new field of electric utility regulation) – the problem was controlling the flow of cars through a limited space. These engineers, concerned with efficiency, saw the allocation of floor space to curbside parking as unbelievably wasteful. Street railway promoters, too, pointed out the greater efficiency of the streetcar for transporting the same number of people in a smaller space.

Both of these problem definitions, however, threatened automotive interests. A benefit of the historical detail in this book in regards to Norton's argument is the convincing timeline: in 1923-1924, car manufacturers in the United States suffered a slump in sales. Norton argues that both problem definitions threatened car sales: the reputation of the car as a killer, and the idea that there were too many cars for the city streets. Thus, he argues, the charge of motordom was to redefine these problems in a way that didn't marginalize the car's position in the city, ensuring their continued ability to do business. Responding to the negative reputation of the automobile and the motorist, they redefined the safety issue as one of recklessness. Children were reckless for playing in the street, and a small minority of motorists were reckless for not following the rules of the road. Motordom also feared market saturation; the growth of the industry depended on "making space" for cars. The congestion issue was redefined as one of "floor space" and market logic: streets shouldn't be treated as a public utility, the use of which should be regulated – they should be physically expanded to meet the increasing demand for space placed upon them by motorists.

While Norton presents these problem redefinitions as stemming from a diversity of stakeholders and interests, not explicitly painting the new definitions as a conspiracy borne from Big Car, his examples nonetheless paint that picture. The shift from "traffic engineering" to "roadway engineering" (making roads larger, rather than controlling the flow of traffic) as the "state of the science" came from the authority of the Erskine Bureau for Street Traffic Research, which was established in 1925 as the first traffic institute in the country and was almost entirely funded by the Studebaker automobile company. The 1927 Model Municipal Traffic Ordinance, which provided a template for cities to institutionalize pedestrians' confinement to the sidewalks, was drafted in great part by the National Automobile Chamber of Commerce. The new perception of safety as the responsibility of the pedestrian was supported by promotional materials and events hosted by the Automobile Association of America in the mid-to-late 1920s. The examples of involved actors are plentiful, but to the reader, it feels like behind each example there inevitably is an organization with "Automobile" in the name.

The city street may not come naturally to contemporary readers as an example of a "natural resource" or part of the "environment." At the time that Norton describes, questions of road use were certainly not framed as environmental (indeed, the idea of "the environment" was not rhetorically prominent in American culture). Today, we can see road use through that lens because of the many environmental consequences of automobility (carbon emissions from internal combustion engines, the hydrological impacts of impermeable surfaces, habitat fragmentation), but that was neither a rhetorical nor governing frame at the time. Despite the lack of explicit environmental framing in Norton's book, I argue that the contentious re-definition of "proper use" of city streets outlined in *Fighting Traffic* describes a process of environmental governance of a scarce natural resource: urban space. In deciding what the city street is for, Americans decided who had access to and who makes decisions about this resource - classic questions of environmental governance.

Scholars of environmental governance examine "*an analytical category with which to examine the multiple and overlapping organizational, institutional, and epistemological systems through which access to natural resources is now structured/negotiated and decisions regarding resource use and environment management are now taken*" (Himley 2008, p 435). Lemos and Agrawal (2006) define environmental governance similarly: "*interventions aiming at changes in environment-related incentives, knowledge, institutions, decision making, and behaviors...the set*

of regulatory processes, mechanisms and organizations through which political actors influence environmental actions and outcomes” (p298). In highlighting epistemological systems and knowledge, these authors’ definitions give space for *Fighting Traffic* to fall neatly into the environmental governance scholarship. The primary theme of his book is one of rhetorical closure – “declines in interpretive flexibility” in which one explanation for a phenomenon comes to dominate (p5). For example, Norton speaks to the capture of “scientific expertise” by automobile interests through research funding, and the proclamation of businesspeople as “experts” by the (federally organized) National Conference on Street and Highway Safety. The use of primary source material allows Norton to justify that these were not incidental or inevitable reorientations. He quotes the chairman of the National Automobile Chamber of Commerce’s safety committee in 1924, saying “Pedestrians must be educated to know that automobiles have rights.” (p207), and a tire company spokesman stating in 1923 “The automobile is too effective a tool to have its efficiency curtailed in the slightest by half-baked ideas...which has as their object a reduction in the number of cars which shall use the streets...” (p185). By 1924, the National Automobile Chamber of Commerce began collecting and publishing its own statistics on “the *real* causes of traffic accidents” – the “reckless pedestrian” (p210). He reveals that participants in this redefinition understood that they were fighting for the future of their industry on rhetorical grounds; this is the “fight” he refers to in his title. Whether this was an explicit or implicit understanding, the automotive interests at the time were participating in what Goldman and Turner (2011) and science and technology scholars before them refer to as a “politics of knowledge,” in which environmental management occurs not only at the level of management decisions, but on the preceding “knowledge claims” that justify those decisions. When safety was redefined as an issue of recklessness rather than speed, a proposed measure of speed limiters on automobiles was excluded from possibility, replaced instead by pedestrian education about the dangers of entering the roadway.

Norton’s description of the epistemological systems which defined use and misuse of city streets is likely the most theoretically meaningful contribution of this work. However, his primary-source analysis of the organizations and institutions involved in this transition also provides a methodological example to scholars seeking to understand how more recent governance structures came to be. In fact, the way in which management of street space in the 1920s was allocated foreshadowed processes of environmental governance that emerged in later years and in other contexts. DePuy et al (2022) define environmental governance more narrowly than Himley and Lemos and Agrawal, referring to “*a historically particular form of intervention that emerged near the end of the 20th century, characterized by a shift from traditional topdown, state-centered development interventions to more decentralized and globalized multiactor modes of administrative control*” (p 948). Norton reveals the beginnings of these shifts at the beginnings of the 20th century, as associationism - an approach to governance that centered a voluntary collaboration between business interests and the state - replaced positive regulation in the eye of decision-makers such as Herbert Hoover, then-Secretary of Commerce (Norton, p179). While administrative control still rested with the state at this time, Norton outlines the influence that nonstate actors had over administrative decisions, with business leaders embedded into federally-organized conferences on road safety and policy design. The industry-led liberalization of the conception of the road, from a public utility to a market commodity (even if managed by the government) was so successful that it has gone unnoticed: only in more recent years have roadway planners begun to revisit and question the idea that congested roads can be solved by additional floor space, an idea that Miller McClintock (the first person to receive a

doctorate for studying traffic) described in 1925, only to walk back by 1927 when receiving research funding from Studebaker (Norton, p156). Those concerned with the neoliberalization of other resources, such as “ecosystem services,” might benefit from applying Norton’s analysis of the institutional and organizational actors involved in this redefinition to their object of study. Likewise, scholars interested in the “sociotechnical and political-economic arrangements that enable data to drive governance” of natural resources (Goldstein and Nost, 2022) might find value in Norton’s depiction of the capture of responsibility for accident statistics by the National Automobile Chamber of Commerce (and later, motor interests embedded in the National Conference on Street and Highway Safety’s Committee on Statistics).

Norton’s work is thorough and focused, but left me with a question probably better attempted by another author. Norton convincingly describes how the vivid descriptions of the car as a child-killer in the early 1920s were replaced with sanitized safety imagery about well-behaved children not entering the streets. This reminded me, however, of the “Stop de Kindermoord” movement of the 1970s in the Netherlands, which used analogous appeals to the death toll on children to rapidly respond to the rising presence of cars in Dutch cities, and turned popular opinion and urban planning back towards safety for all road users. Why weren’t car manufacturers able to respond to this “threat” in the Netherlands? Was the national context, historical context, or relative weakness of the automobile industry responsible? This example suggests that there is space for more work charting the historical relationships of state, industry, and society to better explain *why* the organization of motordom in the 1920s succeeded, and what a modern movement to once again redefine the use and misuse of the city street might look like.

For scholars interested in charting the history and precedents to governance of natural resources, *Fighting Traffic* is an unexpectedly valuable resource. While heavy on historical detail – potentially more detail than a casual reader might want – it also proposes a theoretical framework for understanding the physical transformation of the American city street. In laying out the actors involved in naturalizing the role of cars in the street, Norton provides a methodological example to scholars who may wish to take a similar approach to the politics of knowledge underlying other natural resource questions. For those interested in modern debates about road governance, it is validating (although frustrating) to see that these questions have been in play for over a century.

“The formulation of a problem already contains half its solution.” Ludwick Fleck, 1935 (quoted in Norton, p255)

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